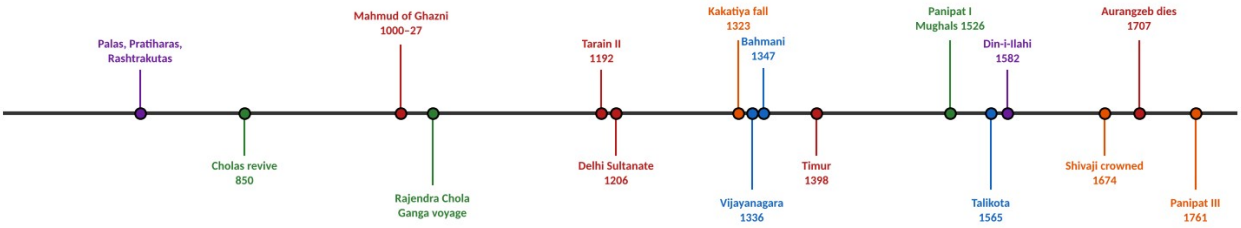
APPSC GROUP 1 / GROUP 2 — HISTORY

Volume 2: Medieval India — explained from the basics

Early medieval north India · South Indian dynasties · Kakatiyas, Reddis and Telugu literature · Delhi Sultanate · Vijayanagara, Bahmani and Qutb Shahis · Bhakti and Sufi · Mughals · Marathas · Society, economy, art and travellers

How to use this volume:
1. Same colours as Volume 1: **Blue** = simple explanation · **Orange** = Andhra Pradesh link · **Red** = exam traps · **Green** = 2-minute revision · **Purple** = self-test.
2. **Who's who tables:** each chapter has a compact table of the key people with a one-line hook (what the person is famous for). Use the hook to remember who is who.
3. Plan: one chapter a day (9 days). Revise green boxes on day 3 and day 10. Then attempt History Mock Test 2.
4. Syllabus covered: Group 1 Prelims Paper I — History of India, medieval portion, with focus on AP; Mains Paper II — social, cultural, political and economic history of AP and India (medieval).

Medieval India on one page (timeline)



Colour code: red = north/Delhi · green = Cholas, Mughals · blue = Vijayanagara/Bahmani · orange = Kakatiyas, Marathas · purple = religion/other

CHAPTER 1 — Early Medieval North India (c. 750–1200)

Rajputs, the Tripartite Struggle and the Turkish invasions

IN SIMPLE WORDS (what / how / why)

After Harsha (647 CE) there was no single empire in the north. Many **regional kingdoms** fought over one prize: **Kanauj**, the rich Ganga–Yamuna capital.
Three powers fought for it for ~200 years — the **Tripartite (Kanauj) Struggle**: **Palas** (Bengal–Bihar, east), **Gurjara-Pratiharas** (Rajasthan–west) and **Rashtrakutas** (Deccan, south). Remember **P-P-R** = Pala, Pratihara, Rashtrakuta.
The same period saw the rise of the **Rajputs** (Chauhans, Paramaras, Chandellas, Solankis/Chalukyas of Gujarat, Gahadavalas) — warrior clans that claimed Kshatriya status (**Agnikula** legend).

Who's who: early medieval north India

Person	Known for	Person	Known for
Muhammad bin Qasim	Arab conquest of Sindh 712	**Mahmud of Ghazni**	17 raids; Somnath 1025 Al-Biruni at court
Muhammad Ghori	Tarain II 1192 founded rule in India	**Prithviraj Chauhan**	Won Tarain I 1191 lost Tarain II
Dharmapala (Pala)	Vikramashila university Buddhist patron	**Bhoja (Paramara)**	Poet-king of Dhara Bhojshala
Amoghavarsha I	Rashtrakuta; wrote Kavirajamarga	**Lakshmana Sena**	Last Sena king Jayadeva's patron

The dynasties in one table

Dynasty	Region / capital	Key rulers and facts
Palas	Bengal, Bihar; Monghyr, Pataliputra	Founder **Gopala** (elected, c. 750). **Dharmapala** — Vikramashila university; **Devapala** — Buddhist patrons; Nalanda, Odantapuri; Mahayana–Tantric Buddhism spread to Tibet via Atisha Dipankara

Dynasty	Region / capital	Key rulers and facts
Gurjara-Pratiharas	Rajasthan, Malwa; Kanauj	**Nagabhata I** held back Arabs; **Mihira Bhoja** (836–85) greatest; **Mahendrapala** — poet Rajashekhara at court; arab traveller Sulaiman praised Bhoja
Rashtrakutas	Deccan; Manyakheta	Founder **Dantidurga** (c. 753) defeated Chalukyas; **Krishna I** built **Kailasa temple, Ellora** (rock-cut); **Amoghavarsha I** — Kannada work **Kavirajamarga**, Jain patron; **Govinda III**, **Indra III** captured Kanauj
Senas	Bengal; Nadia, Lakhnauti	**Vijayasena**, **Ballalasena**, **Lakshmanasena** (court: Jayadeva, author of **Gita Govinda**); Bakhtiyar Khalji took Nadia (c. 1204)
Rajput clans	Chauhans (Ajmer, Delhi); Paramaras (Dhar); Chandellas (Khajuraho); Gahadavalas (Kanauj); Solankis (Gujarat)	**Bhoja Paramara** — Bhojpur, Sanskrit scholar; **Chandellas** — Khajuraho temples (Kandariya Mahadeva); **Prithviraj III Chauhan** — fought Ghori; **Jaichand** of Kanauj

Arab and Turkish invasions

Year	Invader	What happened and what it meant
712	**Muhammad bin Qasim** (Arab, Umayyad)	Defeated **Dahir** of **Sindh**; **Chachnama** is the source. Limited effect — Arabs stayed in Sind–Multan; but Indian science (numerals, astronomy, medicine) reached Baghdad
1000–1027	**Mahmud of Ghazni** (Turk)	17 raids; aim: wealth. **Somnath** (1025–26); defeated **Anandapala** (Hindushahi) at Waihind 1008; scholar **Al-Biruni** came with him — wrote **Tahqiq-i-Hind**; court poet **Firdausi** (**Shahnama**). Did not found an empire in India (only Punjab)
1191–92	**Muhammad Ghori** (Ghurid)	**First Tarain 1191:** Prithviraj Chauhan won. **Second Tarain 1192:** Ghori won → Rajput power collapsed; **Chandawar 1194** broke Gahadavalas (Jaichand). Aim: **empire**, not just loot. Aibak and Bakhtiyar Khalji were his generals

EXAM TRAPS

Ghazni raided for **wealth**; **Ghori** wanted **territory** — a favourite 'compare' question.
Kailasa temple (Ellora) = Rashtrakuta (Krishna I); Pallava = Mahabalipuram/Kanchi; Chalukya = Aihole–Pattadakal. Do not mix.
Al-Biruni wrote **Tahqiq-i-Hind**; Firdausi wrote **Shahnama**; Chachnama = Arab conquest of Sind.

2-MINUTE REVISION

• P-P-R fought for Kanauj. • Pala = Vikramashila; Pratihara = Bhoja; Rashtrakuta = Ellora Kailasa.
• 712 Qasim → 1000 Mahmud → 1192 Ghori (Tarain II) → 1206 Delhi Sultanate.

CHECK YOURSELF

Q. Who built the Kailasa temple at Ellora? **Rashtrakuta king Krishna I.** Q. Author of Gita Govinda? **Jayadeva (Lakshmana Sena's court).**

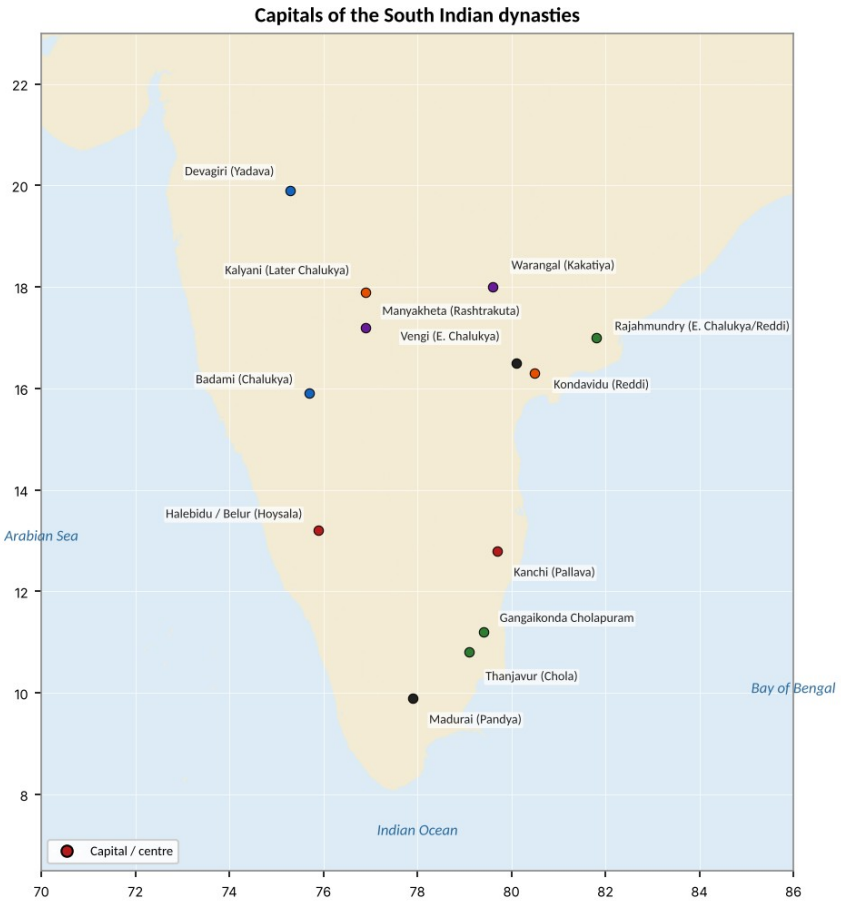
CHAPTER 2 — South Indian Dynasties (c. 550–1300)

Pallavas, Chalukyas, Cholas, Pandyas, Hoysalas, Yadavas

IN SIMPLE WORDS (what / how / why)

In the south, kingdoms were more stable than in the north. The big story: **Pallavas (Kanchi) vs Chalukyas (Badami)** fought for the Krishna–Tungabhadra region; later **Cholas** rose and built a **navy-backed empire** that reached Southeast Asia.
Why this matters for AP: the **Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi** (coastal Andhra) were the Telugu bridge between Chalukyas and Cholas, and **Kulottunga I** (Chola–Chalukya) joined both houses.

Map: where the capitals were



Who's who: the southern rulers

Person	Known for	Person	Known for
Mahendravarman I	Pallava; rock-cut caves Mattavilasa	**Narasimhavarman I**	'Mamalla'; Mahabalipuram beat Pulakeshin II 642
Pulakeshin II	Badami Chalukya beat Harsha; Aihole	**Dantidurga**	Founder of Rashtrakuta rule
Krishna I	Built Kailasa temple at Ellora	**Rajaraja I**	Brihadeshwara, Thanjavur navy; Sri Lanka
Rajendra I	Gangaikonda Cholapuram Srivijaya raid 1025	**Vikramaditya VI**	Kalyani Chalukya Bilhana, Vijnaneshwara
Vishnuvardhana	Hoysala; Belur Chennakesava	**Singhana**	Yadava of Devagiri Hemadri's patron
Kulottunga I	Chalukya-Chola united Vengi and Chola	**Vijayalaya**	Revived Chola power at Thanjavur

Dynasty	Period / capital	Key points
Pallavas	c. 550–900; Kanchipuram	**Simhavishnu** founder; **Mahendravarman I** (Mattavilasa Prahasana; cave temples); **Narasimhavarman I Mamalla** defeated **Pulakeshin II**, took **Vatapi** (642), built **Mahabalipuram** monolithic **rathas** and Shore Temple (later, Rajasimha); **Rajasimha** — **Kailasanatha temple, Kanchi**. Structural stone temples begin. Dandin (Dashakumaracharita) at court
Chalukyas of Badami	c. 543–753; Badami (Vatapi)	**Pulakeshin I** founder; **Pulakeshin II** (610–42) defeated **Harsha** on the Narmada; **Aihole inscription** by court poet **Ravikirti**; Pulakeshin II killed by Narasimhavarman 642. Temples: **Aihole, Pattadakal (Virupaksha), Badami caves**; Ajanta paintings of the period
Eastern Chalukyas (Vengi)	c. 624–1076; Vengi → Rajahmundry	**Kubja Vishnuvardhana** (brother of Pulakeshin II) founder. **Gunaga Vijayaditya**; **Rajaraja Narendra** (1022–61) — **Nannaya** began Telugu **Mahabharatam** (Adi, Sabha, part of Aranya Parvam). Kulottunga I from this line
Cholas (Imperial)	c. 850–1279; Thanjavur → Gangaikondacholapuram	**Vijayalaya** (850) took Thanjavur; **Parantaka I**; **Rajaraja I** (985–1014) — **Brihadisvara temple, Thanjavur** (1010), annexed Sri Lanka north, Maldives; **Rajendra I** (1014–44) — **Gangaikondacholapuram**, naval raid on **Srivijaya** (c. 1025), reached Ganga; **Kulottunga I** (1070–1122) — merged Vengi; **Rajadhiraja**, **Rajendra II**. Decline: **Kulottunga III** → Pandyas and Hoysalas